

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ERITREA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Eritrea must begin with an honest and sobering recognition: this is one of the most closed and tightly controlled states in the world, a Horn-of-Africa nation with no free press, no independent civil society, and no space for the kind of open domestic environmental advocacy this series usually describes, where an indefinite national-service program has been documented by the United Nations and human-rights organisations as a source of conscript labour at and around the country's mines. Eritrea is a land of highland terrace and Red-Sea coast and Danakil desert, its economy increasingly built on mining, its environment shaped by the mines, the land and its greening, the scarce water, and the sea — but its people have almost no safe, open avenue to defend that environment from within. That reality — a closed and repressive state where mining is the economy, where the labour that builds it has been documented as coerced, and where domestic advocacy is not safely possible — is the distinctive and difficult ground of environmental effort here. And it demands, from the very first line, an honest reframing of what this guide can offer: inside Eritrea there is no safe space for open opposition, so the environmental levers here lie almost entirely OUTSIDE the country — in the accountability of the foreign companies that run the mines, in the international frameworks and courts, in the scientific and satellite monitoring that can see what the closed state hides, and in the large Eritrean diaspora — and the protection of anyone inside the country is not one concern among many but the first, last, and governing principle of everything that follows. This guide will treat the holding-to-account of the mining and its labour, the honest weighing of the land and its greening, the stewardship of the water, and the protection of the Red Sea as Eritrea's central environmental questions, pursued almost entirely from outside, through the international, corporate-accountability, scientific, and diaspora channels, and neutral on the government and its politics while honest about the well-documented realities. Eritrea is a state of mine and terrace and sea, closed and controlled and isolated, where the gold and potash feed the economy and the national service builds them. This guide will be honest that there is no safe domestic space, so the work is almost wholly external; that the mining is the economy and its labour documented as coerced; that the greening of the land is real yet built on that same coerced labour; and that no swift or landmark victory, and no safe domestic movement, is to be promised; but it will show that the levers here — the mines and the labour, the land and the trees, the water, the Red Sea, and the external, international, and diaspora channels — are real, and, as the landmark international lawsuit over the country's main mine has shown, genuinely usable from outside.

The Eritrean story teaches two things about the environment here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Eritrean, and it is what gives this guide its particular and sombre force. **Because the mining and its labour can be held to account through the foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks, and the diaspora, because the land and its greening can be honestly weighed and supported from outside, because the water and the Red Sea can be stewarded through international and scientific cooperation, and because the external, international, and diaspora channels are the real avenues a closed state leaves open, the levers run through the mines and from outside: the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels.** That combination — the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels — is the distinctive lever here, and this

guide is built around it, because in one of the world's most closed and repressive states, the strongest and safest ground is the holding-to-account of the mining, the honest weighing of the greening, the stewardship of the water and sea, all from outside, through the international, the corporate-accountability, the scientific, and the diaspora, and above all protecting anyone inside.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes with the utmost seriousness. **There is no safe domestic space, the mining is the economy, its labour documented as coerced, and no safe domestic movement exists.** There is no safe domestic space for open advocacy, so the work is almost wholly external; the mining is the economy and its labour documented as coerced; the greening is real yet built on that coerced labour; and no swift or landmark victory, and no safe domestic movement, is to be promised. This guide does not pretend there is a safe way to organise openly inside Eritrea, or that the mining can be challenged from within, or that anyone inside can be exposed to risk. What it shows is how, through the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels, those who care — the international bodies and courts, the accountability of the foreign companies, the scientific community, and the diaspora — can hold the mining to account, weigh the greening honestly, and steward the water and sea, all from outside, and protecting anyone inside above all.

Most people who care about Eritrea's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a closed and repressive state leaves — which are almost all outside it. They see the mines expand, the labour coerced, the desert press, the sea unstudied — and either despair of a state that permits no domestic advocacy, or overlook the levers that do work: the corporate accountability, the international courts and frameworks, the scientific monitoring, the diaspora. The gap between the mining held to account and the mining unchallenged is here often a gap of method — the method of using the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels together, from outside, and protecting anyone inside.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Eritrean reality as it is, which is one of the world's most closed and repressive states where domestic advocacy is not safely possible, through the external, international, corporate-accountability, scientific, and diaspora channels, and protecting anyone inside above all. It is written for the person — in the international and human-rights and scientific community, among the foreign companies' home countries and accountability frameworks, or in the Eritrean diaspora — who sees the mining and the coerced labour and the pressed land and wants to know what can be done, almost entirely from outside, for the environment of a closed state. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the mines and the labour, the land and the trees, the water, the Red Sea, and the external channels — with the honest and grave qualifiers that there is no safe domestic space, the mining is the economy, its labour documented as coerced, and no safe domestic movement exists, so the work is external, international, corporate-accountability-based, scientific, diaspora-borne, and, above every other consideration, protective of anyone inside.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to one of the world's most closed and repressive states, and pursued almost entirely from outside:

- STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the matter, the impact, and the external framework)
|
- STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION (build the evidence -- from outside, protecting anyone inside)
|
- STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION (build the international, corporate-accountability, and diaspora coalition)
|
- STEP 4: INTERNATIONAL, MINING & LAND (mines, labour, land)
|
- STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY (make it an international mining-and-labour cause)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence** — and all almost entirely from outside. The evidence of the impact and the labour feeds the mining accountability, the greening's honest weighing, and the sea's stewardship at once; the international, corporate-accountability, and diaspora coalition organises; a corporate-accountability action, a scientific documentation, or an international appeal is both a good in itself and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still hard-won — chance of holding the mining to account and stewarding the environment, from outside.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Eritrea's — a closed and repressive state where the levers are almost all external — give a distinctive set:

- **The mines.** The **mining and its labour** can be held to account through the foreign companies, the international courts, and the diaspora — the distinctive lever.
- **The land.** The **land and its greening** can be honestly weighed and supported from outside.
- **The water.** The **water** can be stewarded through international and scientific cooperation.
- **The sea.** The **Red Sea and the Dahlak** can be protected through international marine cooperation.
- **The external channels.** The **external, international, corporate-accountability, scientific, and diaspora channels** are the real avenues a closed state leaves.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest — and dangerous — to promise safe domestic advocacy, or that the mining can be challenged from within, or that anyone inside can safely be exposed. There is **no safe domestic space**; the mining is the **economy**; its labour is **documented as coerced**; and no **safe domestic movement** exists. This guide takes those grave limits with the utmost seriousness — it states them plainly, works almost wholly from outside, and treats the protection of anyone inside as its governing rule — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels — to hold the mining to account and steward the environment, honestly acknowledging the closed and repressive state, the economy-defining and coerced-labour mining, and the absence of any safe domestic movement.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see, soberly, that almost all the levers lie outside the country: the foreign mining companies and their home governments, the international courts and human-rights and environmental frameworks, the scientific and satellite monitoring that can observe what the closed state hides, and the large Eritrean diaspora, because inside Eritrea there is no free press, no independent civil society, no NGOs, and no safe space for open environmental advocacy of any kind. Before you spend a single week, map who actually can act on a matter — which is almost always someone outside the country — and where the leverage is real and safe. And map where the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels apply, because in Eritrea a harm is met not by any domestic movement, which cannot safely exist, but through the foreign companies' accountability, the international frameworks and courts, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora — and always, above all, protecting anyone inside.

The Levels of Decision

An Eritrean environmental effort runs almost entirely outside a closed and repressive state.

The foreign mining companies and their home governments. The **foreign companies that run the mines, and their home governments and regulators** are reachable, accountable, and subject to law and pressure in ways the Eritrean state is not — the central external lever.

The international courts and frameworks. The **international and home-country courts, the human-rights and corporate-accountability frameworks, and the due-diligence standards** carry real leverage, as the landmark mining lawsuit has shown.

The scientific and monitoring community. The **environmental, satellite, and marine scientists and monitoring bodies** can observe and document what the closed state hides — the mines, the land, the sea.

The international and UN bodies. The **UN, human-rights, and international environmental bodies** carry the documentation and the frameworks a closed state cannot be made to supply itself.

The diaspora. The **large Eritrean diaspora** holds knowledge, voice, and the ability to act safely abroad on behalf of an environment its people cannot defend openly at home.

The Journey of a Matter

An Eritrean matter — a mine's pollution or coerced labour, the land and its greening, the scarce water, the pressed Red Sea — is met through the **mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels**. **The mines and the labour are where the great questions are decided, and the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels are what carry the effort** — and using them together, from outside and protecting anyone inside, is the distinctive Eritrean approach. The distinctive levers are the **mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels**. Find out exactly what can be done from outside, and, crucially, **what mine, land, water, or sea is at stake, what corporate-accountability, international, or environmental framework applies, and how the foreign companies, the international courts, the scientists, and the diaspora can act** — because those are where a matter can genuinely be met, and always protecting anyone inside.

Follow the Matter, the Impact, and the External Framework

Behind a matter stand the foreign companies, the international frameworks, the scientists, and the diaspora — and, always here, the safety of anyone inside. Trace who can act from outside, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what mine, land, water, or sea is impacted, what corporate-accountability, international, human-rights, or environmental framework applies, what the science and satellite show, and how the foreign companies, the international courts, the scientists, and the diaspora can act, protecting anyone inside**. Two questions unlock most Eritrean efforts: **What is impacted, and what corporate-accountability or international framework reaches it from outside?** and **Which lever — the mines, the land, the water, the sea, the external channels — can carry it, safely and from outside?** The foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks, the scientists, and the diaspora are, together, the heart of most such efforts here.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a matter, because they are the levers — and almost all are outside. The **foreign mining companies and their home governments**; the **international courts and frameworks**; the **scientific and monitoring community**; the **international and UN bodies**; and the **diaspora**. In Eritrea, the **mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a mine's pollution or coerced labour, the land's greening, the water, or the Red Sea can genuinely be met — through the foreign companies, the international frameworks,

the scientists, and the diaspora — though, honestly, there is no safe domestic space, the mining is the economy, and its labour is documented as coerced, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working from outside, and keep protecting anyone inside above all.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging, gravely, that there is no safe domestic space, the mining is the economy, and its labour is documented as coerced, even as the external levers — the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts and frameworks, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora — give real, if hard-won and wholly external, leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how environmental efforts tend to go against the most closed and repressive states, pursued from outside, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the matter can be **tied to a foreign company, an international court or framework, or scientific documentation**, whether the **international bodies, the diaspora, and the accountability mechanisms** can be engaged, and whether the work can be done **entirely from outside without exposing anyone inside**. Where the effort centres on the mining's external accountability, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the grave knowledge that there is no safe domestic space and the protection of anyone inside governs all.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only (from outside)	15–25%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Mines: corporate accountability & courts	30–50%	years	low–moderate	The mining and its labour held to account
Land / greening honestly weighed	20–40%	years	low	The greening supported and its labour weighed
Water / international & scientific	20–40%	years	low	The water stewarded from outside
Red Sea / Dahlak marine cooperation	25–45%	years	low	The Red Sea and reefs protected
International / UN / human-rights route	30–50%	years	low	The international frameworks engaged
Diaspora / external-advocacy route	35–55%	years	low	The diaspora and external advocacy engaged
All external levers together	30–50%	years	moderate	Mining held to account; environment stewarded

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Eritrea's real leverage is external — the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora: the **mines**, the **land**, the **water**, the **sea**, and the **external channels**. Its constraints are grave and honest: there is **no safe domestic space**, the mining is the **economy**, and its labour is **documented as coerced** — but the corporate accountability, the international frameworks, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora make the external levers here genuinely usable, always protecting anyone inside.

*A note on cost and risk: the levers here — a corporate-accountability action, a scientific documentation, an international appeal, a diaspora campaign — are pursued almost entirely from outside, through the foreign companies and their home governments, the international courts and frameworks, the scientific community, and the diaspora. Because there is no safe domestic space, no one inside the country can safely be involved or exposed, and the protection of anyone inside is the first and overriding consideration of every step. The scarce resources are **the international, corporate-accountability, scientific, and diaspora connections** — all reachable from outside. And because the landmark mining lawsuit succeeded in holding a foreign company accountable at home for conduct in Eritrea, the corporate-accountability lever is genuinely and provenly usable.*

Effectiveness Visualization

MINES + LAND + WATER + SEA + EXTERNAL CHANNELS (all from outside):
 Diaspora / external-advocacy route: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%
 Mines: corporate accountability & courts: ■■■■■■■■■■ 30-50%
 International / UN / human-rights route: ■■■■■■■■■■ 30-50%
 Red Sea / Dahlak marine cooperation: ■■■■■■■■ 25-45%
 Water / international & scientific: ■■■■■■■■ 20-40%

NO SAFE DOMESTIC SPACE / ECONOMY-MINING / COERCED LABOUR -- the hard reality:
 Domestic advocacy: ■■ impossible and unsafe
 Corporate accountability, international & diaspora: ■■■■■■■■■■ the real path
 Mining held to account: ■■■■■■■■ achievable in part
 The impact documented from outside: ■■■■■■■■■■ the reliable foundation

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Eritrea are **the diaspora and external advocacy, the corporate accountability and courts, the international and human-rights route, and the marine cooperation** — used together, all from outside. The corporate-accountability, international, and diaspora levers show the ceiling: the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts, and the diaspora achieve real, if partial, gains, as the landmark lawsuit proved. The absence of any safe domestic space, the economy-defining mining, and the coerced labour show the grave floor: domestic advocacy is impossible and unsafe, the mining is the economy, and the labour is coerced. Most Eritrean efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to hold the mining to account from outside in part — but that domestic advocacy is impossible and unsafe, and the surest result is that the impact is documented from outside and pressed through the foreign companies, the international frameworks, the scientists, and the diaspora, always protecting anyone inside.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The corporate accountability and the diaspora** — Eritrea's distinctive external levers; the foreign companies held to account and the diaspora that can act safely abroad.
2. **The international, UN, and human-rights frameworks** — the courts and frameworks a closed state cannot escape from outside.
3. **The scientific and marine monitoring** — the eyes on the mines, the land, and the sea that the closed state denies.
4. **The land's greening honestly weighed** — the real environmental value credited, the coerced labour behind it named.
5. **The documented impact (from outside)** — the evidence that grounds it all, gathered without exposing anyone inside.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The mining's accountability lies outside** — with the foreign companies, provenly reachable by the courts. **There is no safe domestic space** — so the work is wholly external and protective. **The mining is the economy and its labour coerced** — the central, documented harm. **The greening is real but coerced** — credited honestly, its labour named. **And the protection of anyone inside governs all** — the first and last principle. The through-line: **document the impact from outside; hold the mining and its labour to account through the foreign companies, the courts, and the frameworks; weigh the greening honestly, crediting its value and naming its coerced labour; steward the water and the Red Sea through international and scientific cooperation; use the international, corporate-accountability, scientific, and diaspora channels; and protect anyone inside above all** — because an effort that does can genuinely hold the mining to account from outside in part, while being honest that there is no safe domestic space, the mining is the economy, and its labour is coerced.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact matter — and the leverage, which here lies almost entirely outside: the foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora. Vague concern goes nowhere, and domestic advocacy is impossible and unsafe; an effort aimed at "this matter impacting this mine, land, water, or sea, which a corporate-accountability, international, or scientific lever can reach from outside, carried by the foreign companies, the courts, or the diaspora, protecting anyone inside" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What is impacted?** This is the first question here. What **mine, land, water, or sea** is impacted — the polluting or coerced-labour mine, the degraded or greened land, the scarce water, the pressed Red Sea.
- 2. What external framework reaches it?** What **corporate-accountability, international, human-rights, or environmental framework** reaches the impact from outside — the foreign companies' due diligence, the courts, the international frameworks, the scientific monitoring.
- 3. Is it the mines, the land, or the sea?** Whether the matter is one of the **mines and labour, the land and greening, or the water and Red Sea** — for each has its external levers.
- 4. What external framework and safety apply?** What **external framework** applies, and **how is anyone inside protected** — for there is no safe domestic space and the safety of anyone inside governs all.
- 5. How can the external actors act, protecting anyone inside?** How the **foreign companies, the international courts, the scientists, and the diaspora** can act — from outside, and never exposing anyone inside.

A Worked Example

Suppose evidence emerges — from escaped conscripts, from satellite imagery, from the diaspora — that a mine operated by a foreign company is polluting a watershed and relying on coerced national-service labour, while the closed state permits no inspection, no press, and no domestic complaint of any kind.

Working the five questions: **what is impacted? What external framework reaches it? Is it the mines, the land, or the sea? What external framework and safety apply?** And how can the external actors act, protecting anyone inside? The driver is the mine's pollution and coerced labour, with the foreign company's accountability, the international courts and due-diligence frameworks, the scientific and satellite

documentation, and the diaspora as the levers — all external, and protecting anyone inside above all.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the mine harms and coerces and nothing can be done inside" to a real, careful, external effort: document the pollution and the coerced labour through satellite imagery, escaped-worker testimony gathered safely abroad, and scientific analysis — never exposing anyone inside; press the foreign company and its home government through the corporate-accountability and due-diligence frameworks and, where possible, the courts, as the landmark lawsuit did; engage the international, human-rights, and environmental bodies; and mobilise the diaspora — all from outside, and protecting anyone inside above all. That is a workable effort suited to Eritrea — one that holds the mining and its labour to account from outside, through the foreign companies, the courts, and the diaspora, without exposing a single person inside.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here it must be built entirely from outside, without exposing anyone inside, for a clear record of the impact and the labour is what moves the foreign companies, the international courts, and the frameworks. A foreign company, a home-country court, an international body, and the diaspora all move on evidence — and for Eritrea, a clear record of the impact and the labour, gathered safely from outside, is precisely what an external effort turns into a real result, so build it well, and protect anyone inside above all. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Matter, the Impact, and the External Framework

Get the facts the effort turns on — from outside. Identify the **matter and the impact** — the mine's pollution or coerced labour, the land, the water, the sea — and, decisively here, **the mine, land, water, or sea it impacts and the external framework that reaches it**: the foreign companies' due diligence, the courts, the international and human-rights frameworks. Establish exactly **what is threatened, what it impacts, and what external framework reaches it**, because the impact-against-the-external-framework is the effort's foundation — and never through anyone exposed inside.

Layer 2: The Impact, the Science, and the Labour

Document the impact and the labour with the evidence. Establish the **environmental impact** — the mine's pollution, the land degradation, the water and sea harm — and the **labour** — drawing on **satellite and scientific analysis, escaped-worker and diaspora testimony gathered safely abroad, the human-rights documentation (the UN and NGO reports), and the corporate and trade records**. This impact-and-labour evidence, grounded in the scientific monitoring and the human-rights documentation and gathered without exposing anyone inside, turns the concern into a documented case the foreign companies, the courts, and the international bodies will act on.

Layer 3: The Case, the External Framework, the Channel, and the Safety

Finally, document the case and the external path. Does the **impact** involve a foreign company, an international standard, a human-rights norm, or an environmental harm? What **external framework** — corporate-accountability, court, international, human-rights — applies? Which **foreign-company, court, international, or diaspora channel** will carry it? And how will **anyone inside be protected**? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case the external channels can act on — without exposing anyone inside. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented impact, an

applicable external framework, an external channel, and the absolute protection of anyone inside are exactly what let an Eritrean effort hold the mining to account from outside. Build it well, and the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels become the effort's genuine strength — always protecting anyone inside.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here almost all of it must be gathered from outside: the satellite and scientific analysis, the human-rights documentation, the escaped-worker and diaspora testimony, the corporate and trade records. Here is where the material tends to live in an Eritrean effort, and how to get it — with the **impact**, the **labour**, the **external framework**, and the **safety of anyone inside** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, from outside, not a menu to admire.

The Matter and External-Framework Record

Start with the matter and the external framework. **The corporate and trade records, the human-rights and international reports, and the scientific and satellite analysis** establish the matter and the impact from outside; the distinctive strengths here are the **corporate-accountability and court frameworks** and the **international, human-rights, and scientific frameworks**. Establish the **matter, the impact, and the external framework that reaches it**, drawing on the corporate, human-rights, and scientific records. Establish exactly **what is threatened, what it impacts, and what external framework reaches it**, because a matter reachable through a foreign company, a court, or scientific monitoring is strong ground against a closed state.

The Impact, Science, and Labour Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **impact evidence** — the mine's pollution, the land degradation, the water and sea harm — and the **science and the labour** — drawing on **satellite and scientific analysis, the marine and land data, escaped-worker and diaspora testimony gathered safely abroad, and the human-rights documentation (the UN Commission of Inquiry and NGO reports on the coerced labour)**. Eritrea's mines and land can be observed by satellite and its labour documented from the testimony of those who have escaped, so much of this evidence can be gathered from outside; marshalling it, without exposing anyone inside, is what turns the concern into a documented, actionable case.

The External-Framework, Corporate, and International Record

Document the levers of the external frameworks. Gather the record of **the foreign companies, their home governments, and the corporate-accountability and due-diligence frameworks; the international, human-rights, and court frameworks (and the landmark mining lawsuit's precedent); and the environmental, mercury, and marine frameworks**. A network of allies that understand the corporate-accountability frameworks, the courts, and the international leverage hold the levers that hold the mining to account from outside.

The Scientific, Diaspora, and International Record

Document the wider external levers. Gather the record of the **environmental, satellite, and marine scientists and monitoring bodies; the international, human-rights, and UN bodies; and the large Eritrean diaspora and its networks**. A coalition joined across the scientists, the international bodies, and the diaspora holds levers that reach a closed state from outside, where no domestic effort safely can — and the diaspora, above all, can act and speak safely on behalf of an environment its people cannot defend

openly at home.

The People, the Safety, and the External Path

Finally, and most importantly, map the human terrain and the safety it demands — which here is the paramount consideration of everything. Who is affected — the **communities near the mines, the conscript workers, the future generations, and the wider Horn and Red Sea** — and who can act safely: the **foreign companies' accountability, the international courts and bodies, the scientists, and the diaspora**, all outside, since there is no safe domestic space. And how does the effort **protect every single person inside and act wholly from outside**? An Eritrean effort is advanced through the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels — so map that external coalition deliberately, act wholly from outside, and let the protection of anyone inside govern absolutely every step, for in a state this closed and repressive, no environmental gain is worth the exposure of a single person inside.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in the starkest light of any guide in this series, because Eritrea permits no safe domestic opposition of any kind — no free press, no civil society, no NGOs, no protest — so the "opposition" that works is not domestic at all but the external coalition of the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts and bodies, the scientists, and the diaspora, acting wholly from outside and protecting anyone inside above all. The task is to build a coalition — of foreign-company accountability, international and court frameworks, scientists, and diaspora — that holds the mining to account and stewards the environment, entirely from outside, and never exposing anyone inside.

Why the External Coalition Is the Only Safe and Effective One

In Eritrea, the coalition that can act is wholly external, because a closed and repressive state permits no domestic advocacy, but the foreign companies are accountable at home, the international courts and frameworks carry real leverage, the scientists can monitor from outside, and the diaspora can act safely abroad. That coalition supplies what an effort runs on: the corporate-accountability and due-diligence pressure on the foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks (whose power the landmark mining lawsuit proved), the scientific and satellite monitoring that sees what the state hides, the international and human-rights bodies, and the diaspora that can speak and act for an environment its people cannot defend openly at home. When the corporate-accountability mechanisms, the courts, the scientists, and the diaspora act together, from outside, they become a genuine force — and one that need never expose a single person inside. **A coalition that is external, corporate-accountability-based, court-borne, scientific, and diaspora-led here is not a weaker substitute for a domestic movement; it is the only safe and effective form defence can take against a state this closed — the real foundation of an Eritrean effort, holding the mining to account and stewarding the environment from outside, while everyone inside is protected.**

Finding the Coalition

Begin not with any domestic organising, which is impossible and unsafe, but with those who can act safely from outside — the **corporate-accountability and due-diligence networks, the international and human-rights bodies, the scientists, and the diaspora** — and protect everyone inside. Widen to the wider international, legal, and scientific networks that share the stake in Eritrea's environment and its coerced labour. Name the shared stake — **the mines and their labour, the land, the water, and the Red Sea of a people who cannot defend them openly at home** — because Eritrea's environment is a stake its

own people cannot safely champion, so the world and the diaspora must. Frame the effort around holding the mining to account and stewarding the environment, from outside, protecting anyone inside above all.

Coalition-Building, Through the External Channels

A coalition allied is stronger than any single actor, and for Eritrea it is built wholly through the external channels. Reach to the **corporate-accountability and due-diligence networks and the foreign companies' home governments**; the **international, human-rights, and court frameworks**; the **environmental, satellite, and marine scientists**; the **international and UN bodies**; and the **Eritrean diaspora and its networks**. Frame the coalition around the mines, the land, the water, and the sea. Build breadth through the corporate-accountability, the international, the scientific, and the diaspora channels, and protect everyone inside — for the coalition's strength is precisely that it is external, safe, and reaches the foreign companies, the courts, and the frameworks a closed state cannot escape.

Sustaining the Effort

Eritrean efforts are sustained through the external channels. Keep the coalition **connected, external, and safe**, and centred on the corporate accountability and the diaspora; mark real steps — a corporate-accountability action, a court precedent, a scientific documentation, an international resolution, a diaspora campaign. And keep the effort grounded in the shared environment its own people cannot defend openly, and in the absolute protection of anyone inside. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the corporate-accountability mechanisms, the courts, the scientists, and the diaspora, acts wholly from outside, and protects everyone inside.

STEP 4: INTERNATIONAL, MINING & LAND CHALLENGES — THE MINES, THE LABOUR, AND THE LAND

This is where an Eritrean effort is realistically advanced — not through any domestic movement, which cannot safely exist, but through the **holding-to-account of the mining and its labour, the honest weighing of the land and its greening, and the stewardship of the water and the Red Sea** — carried wholly from outside, through the corporate-accountability, international, scientific, and diaspora channels, and protecting anyone inside above all. Here the mining, land, and sea levers come together, because in Eritrea a matter can be met through the foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks, the scientists, and the diaspora — from outside.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest and grave truth. The levers are **real but wholly external, and the mining entangled with coerced labour**. The mining accountability is **real through the foreign companies and the courts, as the landmark lawsuit proved, though the mining is the economy and its labour coerced**; the land's greening is **real yet built on coerced labour, to be weighed honestly**; the water and sea stewardship is **possible through international and scientific cooperation**; and there is **no safe domestic space**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the mining and its labour held to account from outside, the greening honestly weighed, and the water and Red Sea stewarded** — real, if partial, outcomes centred on the external accountability, in a closed state, and never at the cost of anyone inside. Enter this front clear-eyed: the mines, the land, and the sea are Eritrea's distinctive levers, strongest when centred on **the corporate accountability, the courts, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora** — but there is no safe domestic space, and the protection of anyone inside governs all.

The Mines and the Labour

The first front is the mines and the labour. The **mining that is Eritrea's economy — the gold, copper, and zinc mine and the potash project, run by foreign companies with the state — and the indefinite national-service conscript labour documented at and around the mines** can be held to account through **the accountability of the foreign companies and their supply chains, the corporate due-diligence and home-government frameworks, the international courts (whose power the landmark lawsuit proved when it held a foreign company answerable at home for conduct in Eritrea), the human-rights documentation, and the international pressure.** Use the mines and the labour, because the mining is the economy and cannot be challenged from within a closed state, but the foreign companies that run it are accountable at home — subject to due-diligence duties, to the courts, and to the pressure of their home governments and investors — so the real and proven lever is to hold those companies to account for both the environmental harm and the coerced labour, as the landmark lawsuit did when it refused to let a foreign miner escape answering, at home, for what was done at its Eritrean mine. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this mining front, honestly, for it is the defining lever an Eritrean effort holds and the one that has already been proven to work. Its power lies in a structural fact that the closure cannot erase: the mines may sit inside an unreachable state, but the companies that own and operate them are headquartered in open, rule-of-law countries, listed on their exchanges, answerable to their courts, their regulators, their investors, and their publics — and so a harm sealed off from any domestic challenge becomes reachable through the company's home jurisdiction. The landmark lawsuit made this concrete and durable: it established that a foreign miner could be sued at home for conduct at its Eritrean operation, that the closed state's own courts offered no adequate alternative, and that claims grounded in international norms could proceed — a precedent that outlives any single case. Its limits are equally real and must be stated plainly: the mining is the whole economy and will not be surrendered; the state controls the ground and the labour; and the companies can change hands to owners in jurisdictions less exposed to such accountability. Understanding both means using the mining front for what it can genuinely deliver — the due-diligence pressure, the court accountability, the home-government and investor leverage, the documentation of harm and coerced labour — while being honest that the mining endures, so the aim is to hold its foreign operators steadily to account from outside rather than to end an economy from within.

The Land and the Greening

The second front is the land and its greening. The **land — the Horn's desertification, drought, and degradation, and Eritrea's real programmes of terracing, check-dams, and afforestation** can be honestly weighed and supported through **the crediting of the genuine environmental value of the soil-and-water conservation and tree-planting, the honest naming of the coerced national-service labour on which much of it relies, and the international and scientific cooperation that could support such restoration on a just basis.** Use the land and the greening, because Eritrea's terracing and afforestation deliver real environmental benefit against a pressing desert — a genuine greening that this guide credits honestly — even as much of it relies on the same coerced national-service labour that shadows the mines, a truth this guide names with equal honesty; so the lever is to weigh both truths together, crediting the environmental value while naming the coerced labour, and to support, through international and scientific cooperation, the restoration of a degraded land on a just rather than a coerced basis. This double honesty is worth pausing on, because the land front is where an Eritrean effort is most tempted to simplify, and must refuse to. It would be easy, and false, to dismiss the greening entirely because of the labour behind it — for the terraces really do hold the soil, the check-dams really do slow the water, the trees really do push back the desert, and the environmental gain is real and worth crediting plainly. It would be equally easy, and equally false, to celebrate the greening while averting the eyes from the coercion — for

much of that restoration has been built by conscripts of an indefinite national service, and to praise the result while ignoring the coercion would be to launder it. The honest and only defensible path is to hold both truths at once, without letting either cancel the other: to say clearly that the restoration of a degraded land is genuinely valuable and genuinely needed, and to say with equal clarity that it must not rest on coerced labour, and that international and scientific support should be offered precisely to help such restoration happen on a just, voluntary, and properly compensated basis. An effort that holds this double honesty neither dismisses a real environmental good nor excuses a real coercion, and it is the only stance on the land front that is both truthful and humane.

The Water and the Red Sea

The third front is the water and the sea. The **scarce water and the many state-built dams, and the long Red Sea coast with its relatively pristine Dahlak reefs** can be stewarded and protected through **the international and scientific cooperation on the water, and the international marine-conservation cooperation on the Red Sea and the Dahlak Archipelago's understudied but valuable reefs and marine life**. Use the water and the Red Sea, because the water is scarce and the Red-Sea coast holds one of the region's less-spoiled marine environments in the Dahlak islands, so stewarding them means international and scientific cooperation — the study and monitoring of the water and the reefs, and the international marine-conservation frameworks that could protect a relatively pristine sea before it is degraded. Pursued together — the mines, the land, and the sea — these fronts are how an Eritrean effort holds the mining to account, weighs the greening honestly, and stewards the water and sea, through the corporate-accountability, international, scientific, and diaspora channels, from outside, and protecting anyone inside above all.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each external actor in the language that moves them. The same file of impact and labour becomes different arguments for the foreign companies, the courts, the international bodies, the scientists, and the diaspora. Translate deliberately, and always from outside and protecting anyone inside.

For the Foreign Companies and Their Home Governments

The foreign companies and their home governments respond to **accountability, due diligence, and reputation**. Frame the matter as their responsibility and their risk: here is the environmental harm and the coerced labour at your Eritrean operation, here is your due-diligence duty and your legal and reputational exposure. Give them the documented impact and labour, and press for the accountability, the remediation, the due diligence. Make it concrete: *here is the pollution and the coerced labour, here is the duty and the exposure you cannot ignore, as the landmark lawsuit made plain*. This is the argument a foreign company and its home government must weigh.

For the International Courts and Frameworks

The international courts and frameworks respond to **the law, the precedent, and the norms**. Frame the matter as one their law and precedent reach: here is the conduct, the international norm, the precedent (the landmark lawsuit) that lets a foreign company be held answerable at home. Give them the case, and press for the accountability, the ruling, the precedent. A court or framework armed with the precedent can hold a foreign company to account for conduct in Eritrea.

For the International and Human-Rights Bodies

The international and human-rights bodies respond to **the documented harm and the frameworks**. Frame the matter as one their documentation and frameworks reach: here is the environmental harm and the coerced labour, the UN and NGO record, the frameworks and pressure you can bring. Give them the case, and press for the documentation, the resolutions, the pressure. The international and human-rights bodies carry the record and the frameworks a closed state cannot escape.

For the Scientists

The scientists respond to **the evidence and the monitoring**. Frame the matter as one their science and satellite can reach: here is the harm to the mine's watershed, the land, or the reef, the data and monitoring needed. Give them the case, and press for the analysis, the satellite monitoring, the marine study. The scientists can see and document what the closed state hides.

For the Diaspora

The diaspora responds to **the homeland, the environment, and the ability to act safely abroad**. Translate the file into the story of a homeland's mines, land, water, and sea that its people cannot defend openly: here is the harm, the coerced labour, the environment you can champion safely from abroad. Frame it as the defence, from abroad, of a homeland's environment. Keep it accurate and safe, never exposing anyone inside. And the diaspora, acting safely abroad, is the voice an oppressed environment cannot raise at home.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, act wholly from outside, and protect every person inside. Your credibility rests on the real impact and the real labour — the corporate-accountability, international, scientific, and diaspora case, external and protective; and the safety of every person inside is the paramount and overriding consideration. State the impact and the labour precisely, tie them to the mines, the land, or the sea, and press through the foreign companies, the courts, the international bodies, the scientists, and the diaspora. An effort that is precise, external, and protective is far more effective than one that overreaches, and infinitely safer than any that would expose a single person inside the country.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into support — and here, for one of the world's most closed states, there is no domestic media and no safe domestic voice at all, so the "media" that works is wholly international: the global coverage, the human-rights and scientific reporting, and the diaspora's voice that reach the world's concern for a closed state's coerced labour and hidden environment, always protecting anyone inside. The story — a closed state whose economy is built on mining worked by coerced labour, its land greened by that same labour, its environment hidden from the world — resonates internationally, if told carefully and from outside.

Why Media Matters

The foreign companies, the international bodies, and the world behave differently when the harm and the coerced labour are visible. Media does three things here: it **exposes to the world the environmental harm and the coerced labour a closed state hides**, it **raises the international pressure** on the foreign companies and the frameworks, and it **amplifies the diaspora's voice** for a homeland that cannot speak.

But there is no domestic media and no safe domestic voice, so the media effort runs wholly through **international coverage, human-rights and scientific reporting, and the diaspora**, protecting everyone inside and exposing no one.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the mining and the coerced labour. The strongest frame is striking, concrete, and true: *a closed state whose economy is built on foreign-run mines documented to use coerced national-service labour, whose land is greened by that same labour, and whose environment the world is not allowed to see*. Put the mining and the coerced labour first, because the story of a foreign-run mine worked by coerced labour in one of the world's most closed states is striking and internationally resonant, and it frames the effort around the external accountability that can reach it. Keep it scrupulously accurate and safe; and never expose a single person inside, and never name anyone whose safety could be endangered. The Eritrean story is powerful because the coerced labour is documented, the mining foreign-run and reachable, and the landmark lawsuit has shown the accountability is real.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, all external and safe. **International coverage and human-rights reporting** for the world; **the corporate-accountability, legal, and investor channels** for the foreign companies; **the scientific channels** for the environmental evidence; and **the diaspora's networks and voice** for the homeland that cannot speak. Because the story is one of foreign-run mining and coerced labour, the international, corporate-accountability, and diaspora channels carry it, the safety of everyone inside comes first, and no one inside is ever exposed — the mining, the coerced labour, and the hidden environment are the story's power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, safe, external, and protective — the aim is holding the mining to account and stewarding the environment from outside, framed around the mines, the land, and the sea, and never anything that could expose or endanger a single person inside. Frame the story around the mines, the labour, the land, and the sea, and handle the government, its politics, the national service, and the geopolitics factually and neutrally while remaining honest about the well-documented realities, keeping the focus on the environment and the labour. Handle every sensitive matter through the careful external record, and never through anyone inside. And sustain the story across the slow work. Above all, let the documented coerced labour, the foreign-run mining, and the landmark accountability carry the story, because that is where an Eritrean effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real matter, keep it factual and safe, centre on the external accountability, and never expose anyone inside. Here the foreign companies, the international courts and frameworks, the scientists, and the diaspora win. These are addressed to external actors, never to anyone inside.

8A: To a Foreign Mining Company's Home Government or Regulator

Subject: Due-diligence and accountability for [company]'s operations in Eritrea

To [home government / regulator],

We write regarding [company]'s mining operations in Eritrea, and the documented environmental harm and coerced national-service labour associated with mining there. We respectfully urge the fullest due-diligence, accountability, and remediation under your frameworks. We attach the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8B: The Mining / Corporate-Accountability Case

Subject: Environmental harm and coerced labour at [mine]

To [company / accountability body / court],

The [mine] in Eritrea is associated with [pollution / coerced national-service labour], as documented by [the UN / NGOs / scientific analysis]. We respectfully urge accountability, remediation, and the due diligence and standards the landmark precedent affirmed. We attach the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8C: The Land / Greening Case

Subject: Supporting Eritrea's land restoration on a just basis

To [international / development / environmental body],

Eritrea's terracing and afforestation deliver real environmental benefit, yet rely substantially on coerced national-service labour. We respectfully urge support for such restoration on a just, non-coerced basis, crediting its value while addressing its labour. We attach the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8D: The Water / Red Sea Case

Subject: International cooperation on Eritrea's water and the Dahlak reefs

To [international / marine / scientific body],

Eritrea's scarce water and its relatively pristine Dahlak Red-Sea reefs merit international scientific cooperation and marine conservation. We respectfully urge the study, monitoring, and protection of these resources. We attach the science.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8E: To an International or UN Body

Subject: Eritrea's mining, coerced labour, and hidden environment

To [UN / international body],

We write regarding the environmental harm and coerced national-service labour associated with Eritrea's foreign-run mining, hidden by a closed state, and respectfully seek the documentation, the frameworks, and

the international pressure that only external bodies can provide. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name / organisation, contact]

8F: To a Scientific or Monitoring Body

Subject: Satellite and scientific monitoring of Eritrea's mines and reefs

Dear [research / monitoring institution],

We write regarding [the mine's pollution / the land / the Dahlak reefs] in Eritrea, observable from outside, and respectfully seek your satellite and scientific monitoring and analysis of what the closed state hides. We provide what we have.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: The foreign-run mines worked by coerced labour in one of the world's most closed states

Dear [journalist / editor],

Eritrea's economy is built on foreign-run mines documented to use coerced national-service labour, its land greened by that same labour, its environment hidden from the world — and a landmark lawsuit has shown a foreign miner can be held answerable at home for what is done there. There is a striking, resonant, and safely documentable story here, and we can provide the evidence without exposing anyone inside.

Sincerely,

[Name, contact]

8H: To the Diaspora

Subject: Our homeland's mines, land, and sea — let us defend them from abroad

Dear friends,

Our homeland's mines are worked by coerced labour, its land greened by the same, its water and sea unstudied and unprotected — and our people cannot defend them openly at home. But we, abroad, can: through the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts and bodies, the scientists, and our own voice, we can hold the mining to account and steward our homeland's environment, safely, and without exposing anyone inside. Please join us, from abroad and in safety, in defending the environment our people cannot defend at home.

With respect,

[Name / diaspora network]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a matter is acute — a new mine or expansion, a documented pollution or labour abuse, a threat to the reefs, a foreign company's decision — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work

fastest and most safely here, which means the external documentation, the corporate-accountability and international frameworks, and the diaspora, protecting anyone inside above all.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials, from outside: **what is impacted, and what external framework reaches it.** Identify the immediate matter — a **mine or expansion, a pollution or labour abuse, a reef threat, a company decision** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **foreign company and its home government, the international and human-rights bodies, and the diaspora** at once, because in Eritrea the external documentation, the corporate-accountability and international frameworks, and the diaspora are the fastest routes to real leverage — and protect everyone inside and expose no one from the start.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The foreign company's accountability** can be engaged fast where a company decision or abuse is documented. **The corporate-accountability and due-diligence frameworks** can be invoked quickly. **The international and human-rights bodies** can be alerted fast to a documented harm. **The diaspora** can mobilise quickly and safely abroad. These outpace the slower work of the deep court cases and the systemic change — which must follow — because the foreign companies, the frameworks, and the diaspora can be engaged immediately from outside. Above all, if a foreign company is deciding or a harm is documented, engage the company's accountability and its home government fast, because the foreign company is the readiest external lever the mining offers.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but for Eritrea you can reach the foreign companies, the international bodies, and the diaspora fast, and safely from outside. Reach immediately to the **foreign company and its home government, the international and human-rights bodies, and the diaspora**, protecting everyone inside. A coalition documenting the matter from outside, engaging the foreign company's accountability, and mobilising the international bodies and diaspora is the most rapid Eritrean effort can do. Speed favours the prepared: know the foreign companies, the frameworks, and the safe external channels before the crisis breaks, and expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is not merely tilted but wholly closed: a state that permits no free press, no civil society, no NGOs, no protest, and no domestic environmental advocacy of any kind, whose economy is built on foreign-run mining documented to use coerced national-service labour, and which is isolated, controlled, and largely hidden from outside view. Name it plainly, because pretending there is any safe domestic space, or that the mining can be challenged from within, or that anyone inside can safely be exposed, would each be false and dangerous — but the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts and frameworks, the scientific and satellite monitoring, and the diaspora make even this wholly closed field one where careful, external, protective work can take hold.

Recognising a Wholly Closed Field

The signs are specific and grave. **There is no free press or civil society** — no domestic advocacy possible. **The economy is foreign-run mining** — reachable from outside. **The labour is documented as coerced** — the central harm. **The state is isolated and controlled** — and hides its environment. And **no**

one inside can safely be exposed — the paramount limit. But **the foreign companies' accountability, the international courts, the scientific monitoring, and the diaspora** are real, external levers. This is not a tilt but a closure, worked wholly through the external channels, protecting anyone inside, and never through any domestic effort that cannot safely exist.

Strategies for a Wholly Closed Field

When the field is wholly closed, use only the external levers. Lean on the **foreign companies' accountability**, reachable at home through due diligence, the courts, and their home governments; the **international courts and frameworks**, whose power the landmark lawsuit proved; the **scientific and satellite monitoring**, which sees what the state hides; the **international and human-rights bodies**, which document and pressure; and the **diaspora**, which can act and speak safely abroad. Meet the closure not with any domestic effort, which cannot safely exist, but with the external accountability, the courts, the science, and the diaspora. And build the external coalition over time, because these accumulate into real, if partial, external accountability. A wholly closed field is worked through the foreign companies, the courts, the science, and the diaspora, protecting anyone inside above all.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little against a state this closed and controlled — the mining may expand, the labour may stay coerced, the environment may stay hidden — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the closure is near-total and the state hides much. But even here the work is rarely wholly wasted: **the impact and the coerced labour were documented from outside, a foreign company was held to account, a court precedent was set, and the diaspora's voice was raised** — and every documentation from outside, every measure of corporate accountability, every court precedent, every raising of the diaspora's voice is a real difference, and the landmark lawsuit itself proved that even a closed state's foreign-run mining can be held answerable abroad. Press, safely and from outside, for the mining's accountability and the environment's stewardship; even against near-total closure, the accountability you help build and the harm you help document are real and lasting goods — and, above all, no environmental gain is ever worth the exposure of a single person inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Eritrea, alongside the closure and the coerced labour, there is a real dimension of resource-capture, because the mining is the nation's wealth and its revenues have been documented as flowing to the state and a narrow circle rather than to the population, even as the communities near the mines bear the pollution and the conscripts bear the coerced labour, so there is a genuine risk — indeed a documented pattern — that the gold and potash enrich the few while the many bear the cost. The harm here is partly the capture of a nation's mineral wealth and its people's labour by the state and a narrow elite. The response runs through the external transparency, the corporate accountability, and the international frameworks — never through anyone inside.

Telling Resource-Capture from the Ordinary Closure

Here the harm is resource-capture and coerced labour, and its marks are specific and documented: **the mining revenues opaque and flowing to the state and a narrow circle, the population bearing the pollution and the coerced labour while the few take the wealth, the national service used to supply coerced labour to the mines, and the mineral wealth and the people's labour captured by the state and elite**. The task is to document it from outside and reach it through the external transparency, the

corporate accountability, and the international frameworks, relying on the international and human-rights reporting, the trade and financial records, and the corporate disclosures, keeping strictly to what can be documented from outside and never exposing anyone inside. And note that the same corporate accountability and transparency that expose the coerced labour can also expose the capture of the revenues, and that the foreign companies and their home governments can be pressed to ensure their operations do not fund coercion or capture.

Responding to Resource-Capture — Through External Accountability

Where the resource-capture and coerced labour are real, the response runs through the external accountability. Use the **external transparency and international reporting** to expose where the revenues are captured and the labour coerced. Use the **corporate accountability and due diligence** to press the foreign companies not to fund coercion or capture. Use the **international, human-rights, and court frameworks** to hold the mining answerable, as the landmark lawsuit did. And use the **diaspora** to raise, safely from abroad, the voice the population cannot. Document rigorously from outside, keep strictly to the safely documentable, protect everyone inside, and never expose anyone, for in a state this closed the record must be external and the people inside shielded absolutely. Route the effort through the external transparency, the corporate accountability, and the international frameworks — never through anyone inside, whose exposure is never worth any gain.

A Note on Safety and Protection

This note matters more here than in almost any guide, and governs everything absolutely. Eritrea is one of the world's most closed and repressive states, where there is no safe domestic space of any kind and where exposure can bring the gravest consequences to a person and their family, so this work must be conducted wholly from outside and must protect every single person inside above every other consideration. Work only through the **foreign-company, international, court, scientific, and diaspora channels**, and only from outside; never involve, name, expose, or endanger anyone inside the country, and treat the safety of every person inside as the absolute and overriding consideration of every step; gather testimony only from those safely outside, and shield every source; frame the work as the external accountability of foreign-run mining and the stewardship of a hidden environment, never as anything requiring a domestic actor; and handle the government, the national service, and the geopolitics factually and neutrally while remaining honest about the well-documented realities. Protection here is not one concern among others but the absolute governing rule: the effective and safe path for Eritrea runs wholly through the external channels, and nothing — no accountability, no documentation, no appeal — is ever worth endangering a single person inside one of the world's most repressive states.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all wholly external, protective of everyone inside, and centred on the corporate accountability and the diaspora. Here is how they fit into a single Eritrean effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, all from outside. **Documentation** builds the impact-and-labour file, gathered safely from outside. **Target identification** aims it at the external levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the wholly external coalition, organises the corporate-accountability mechanisms, the

international bodies, the scientists, and the diaspora. **International, mining, and land** work holds the mining to account, weighs the greening, and stewards the sea. **Media**, international and careful, carries the mining-and-labour cause. The impact-and-labour feeds all five at once — a documented matter is a corporate-accountability action, a court case, a scientific documentation, an international appeal, and a diaspora campaign together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, wholly from outside and protecting everyone inside, they compound into real, if partial, external accountability.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the impact and the labour from outside; identify the mines, the land, the water, and the sea; build the external coalition and begin documentation, protecting everyone inside. **Middle (months–years):** hold the mining and its labour to account through the foreign companies and the courts; weigh the greening honestly; and steward the water and Red Sea through international and scientific cooperation. **Later (years):** see the mining and its labour held to account from outside, the greening honestly weighed, and the water and Red Sea stewarded — real, if partial, outcomes centred on the external accountability, and never at the cost of anyone inside. An Eritrean effort works wholly through the foreign companies, the international frameworks, the scientists, and the diaspora; pace it accordingly, and let the protection of everyone inside govern absolutely every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the impact and the labour from outside; hold the mining and its labour to account through the foreign companies, the courts, and the frameworks; weigh the greening honestly, crediting its value and naming its coerced labour; steward the water and the Red Sea through international and scientific cooperation; use the corporate-accountability, international, scientific, and diaspora channels; and protect every person inside above all.** The coalition that presses all five, wholly from outside and protecting everyone inside, is the one that can genuinely hold the mining to account and steward the environment — the kind of result one of the world's most closed states allows, through the external channels alone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Defending the environment in Eritrea is extraordinarily hard, and bound up with one of the world's most closed and repressive states — a nation with no free press, no civil society, no domestic advocacy of any kind, whose economy is built on foreign-run mining documented to use coerced national-service labour, and which is isolated, controlled, and hidden from outside view — and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no safe domestic space, the mining is the economy, its labour documented as coerced, and no safe domestic movement exists. And yet the effort is not futile, because the levers here, though wholly external, are real: the mining and its labour can be held to account through the foreign companies, the international courts, and the frameworks, as the landmark lawsuit proved; the land's greening can be honestly weighed and supported from outside; the water and the Red Sea can be stewarded through international and scientific cooperation; and the external, international, scientific, and diaspora channels are the real avenues a closed state leaves open. Those levers of the mines, the land, the water, the sea, and the external channels are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The mining's accountability is real but wholly external — with the foreign companies, provenly reachable by the courts. There is no safe domestic space, so the work is wholly external and the protection of anyone inside governs all. The greening is real**

yet built on coerced labour — credited and named with equal honesty. And the diaspora is the voice a silenced people cannot raise at home. Hold both truths at once: real, external levers of the corporate accountability, the courts, the science, and the diaspora, and the grave weight of a wholly closed and repressive state.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the absolute protection of everyone inside — that give these efforts their force. Document the impact and the labour from outside. Hold the mining and its labour to account through the foreign companies, the courts, and the frameworks. Weigh the greening honestly. Steward the water and the Red Sea through international and scientific cooperation. Use the corporate-accountability, international, scientific, and diaspora channels. And protect every person inside above all — because against one of the world's most closed states, an effort that holds the mining to account and stewards the environment wholly from outside, centred on the external accountability and keeping every person inside from harm, is the one that is both effective and just.

Eritrea is a Horn-of-Africa nation of highland terrace and Red-Sea coast and Danakil desert, one of the world's most closed and repressive states, where the economy is built on foreign-run mines documented to use coerced national-service labour, where the land is greened by that same labour, and where the environment is hidden from the world and its people cannot defend it openly at home. This guide has hidden none of that — the near-total closure, the coerced labour, the economy-defining mining, the absence of any safe domestic space — and there is no swift or landmark victory, and no safe domestic movement, to promise you. But the levers here, though wholly external, are real and have already been proven: the accountability of the foreign companies that run the mines, held answerable at home by a landmark lawsuit for what is done in Eritrea; the international courts and frameworks; the scientific and satellite monitoring that sees what the closed state hides; and the large diaspora that can act and speak safely abroad for a homeland that cannot. There is no safe domestic space, no way to challenge the mining from within, and no work that does not demand the absolute protection of everyone inside; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted above all on the safety of every person inside one of the world's most repressive states. But the mines and land and water and sea of Eritrea, and the people who bear their cost, are worth every careful, external, protective effort, the levers that run through the foreign companies, the courts, the science, and the diaspora are real and proven, and the patient, wholly external work of holding the mining to account, weighing the greening honestly, and stewarding the water and sea — while every person inside is protected above all — is one that the international community, the accountability frameworks, the scientists, and the Eritrean diaspora can genuinely do. So can you.